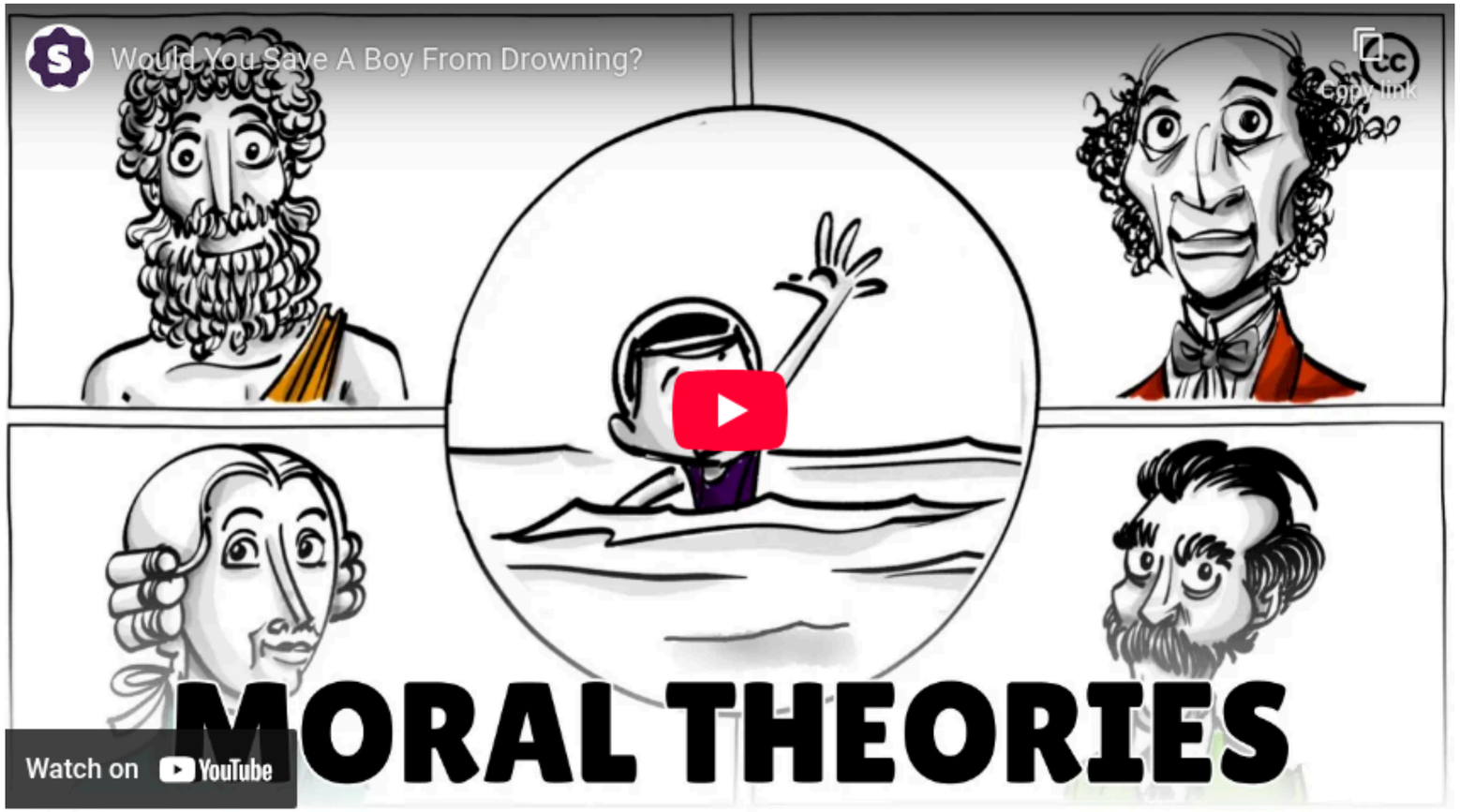
Ethics

Dr. Rabab Ali Abumalloh

Ollscoil Teicneolaíochta an Atlantaigh

Atlantic Technological University


Would You Save A Boy From Drowning?
copy link
MORAL THEORIES
Watch on YouTube

DILEMMA AND MORAL DILEMMA

Dilemma refers to a situation in which a tough choice has to be made between two or more options, especially more or less equally undesirable ones. Not all dilemmas are moral dilemmas

DILEMMA AND MORAL DILEMMA

Suppose you have a teacher who is very strict and is known for failing half of the students in the class.
The teacher gives the entire class an assignment to be submitted in two days.

Because you are aware of the teacher's reputation, you put in extra effort and complete the assignment on time.
However, most of your classmates are unable to finish their work. They encourage everyone in the class not to submit the assignment as a form of protest, arguing that the deadline is unfair.
You now feel pressured.

DILEMMA AND MORAL DILEMMA

QUESTION:

1. Is there a moral issue here? If there is, what moral issue is involve?

2. What kind of moral dilemma is involve in this situation?

3. What is your action and explain why you choose this action?

Humans

1. Only human beings are rational, autonomous and self conscious.

2. Only human beings can act morally or immorally.

3. Only human beings are part of the moral community.

ONLY HUMAN BEINGS CAN BE ETHICAL

(41) Semester Ethics Course condensed into 22mins (Part 1 of 2) - YouTube

FREEDOM AS A FOUNDATION OF MORALITY

Ollscoil Teicneolaíochta an Atlantaigh
Atlantic Technological University

Case Study: Maya and Moral Responsibility

Maya lost her parents at the age of eight during a military encounter. She was later adopted by the leader of a rebel group. Growing up within that environment, she was taught that the government was the enemy and responsible for her parents' death.

Over time, she became deeply involved in the group's operations, believing she was fighting injustice.

Years later, while living under a different identity, she met a government soldier. Through this relationship, she was exposed to different perspectives and began to question her long-held beliefs. She eventually realized that much of what she had been taught was misleading or false.

Maya later stated:

"If I had known the truth, I would never have participated in those actions."

FREEDOM AS A FOUNDATION OF MORALITY

Answer the following questions:

1. What factors can hinder an individual's freedom of choice?
2. Try to recall a situation in which you felt "forced" to make a wrong decision due to inadequate, incomplete, or misleading information.
   - Did you feel morally responsible for the consequences of that decision? Why or why not?
3. If a person lacks the ability—due to illiteracy or limited education—to fully understand and evaluate the moral significance of their actions, should they be exempt from moral responsibility for the consequences of their decisions? Explain your reasoning.
4. In some legal systems, a criminal suspect may become a state witness in exchange for reduced punishment.

Discuss the moral implications of authorities adopting this practice in the pursuit of justice. Does this approach promote justice, or does it compromise fairness?

FREEDOM AS A FOUNDATION OF MORALITY

Freedom of Choice Is Impaired When:

1. Decisions are based on deceptive, false, or misleading information.
2. When individuals act on lies or incomplete facts, their ability to make informed and autonomous choices is compromised.
3. There is a lack of mental capacity or cognitive ability.
4. If a person is unable to fully understand, evaluate, or reason through the consequences of their actions, their freedom of choice is significantly limited.
5. There are compulsive forces or undue influences.
6. Manipulation, or excessive pressure from others can restrict a person's ability to make voluntary and independent decisions.

Minimum Requirements for Morality: Reason and Impartiality

1. Reason

Reason, as a requirement for morality, means that ethical decisions should be guided by rational reflection rather than emotion alone. Human feelings and intuitions may play an important role in moral judgment; however, they should be examined and guided by logical reasoning.

Moral decisions should be supported by:

- Clear justification
- Consistent principles
- Evidence and thoughtful consideration

In short, morality requires the ability to give reasons for one's actions.

Minimum Requirements for Morality: Reason and Impartiality

2. Impartiality
Impartiality means that each person's interests and perspectives must be considered equally.

No individual's interests should automatically count more simply because of personal preference, status, or relationship.

Moral reasoning requires fairness — similar cases should be treated similarly, and personal bias should not determine moral judgment.

What is Cultural Relativism? Definition, Strengths, and Criticisms | Theory to Go 3
Copy link
ACADEMICS
What is
Cultural
Relativism
Strengths, Weaknesses,
and Criticisms
Watch on YouTube

Definition of Culture

Culture refers to the shared patterns of learning, values, beliefs, and behaviors that individuals acquire while growing up within a particular social group.
It includes:

- Attitudes and value systems
- Standards of morality
- Rules of etiquette and social conduct
- Perceptions of reality
- Language and communication styles
- Notions of the “proper” way to live
- Beliefs, traditions, and ideas

Culture shapes how individuals understand the world, interpret experiences, and make moral judgments.

C.S. Lewis on Moral Differences

C.S. Lewis argues:
"Although there are differences between the moral ideas of one time or country and those of another, the differences are not really very great."
His point is that while cultures may vary in customs and practices, there are underlying moral similarities across societies.
He further suggests:
If we claim that the morality of one society is better or worse than that of another, we are implicitly appealing to a moral standard that exists beyond both societies.
In other words:

- To compare two moral systems,
- We must assume a standard by which both are measured.
- Therefore, that standard must be real and not merely invented.

Clive Staples Lewis (1898–1963) was a British writer, literary scholar, and Christian thinker. He is best known for both his fiction and his philosophical writings on morality and religion.

Moral Relativism

Moral Relativism

Moral relativism is the view that no action is objectively right or wrong. It holds that there is no single, universal moral standard by which we can evaluate the truth or correctness of moral judgments.

According to moral relativism:

- What is considered right or wrong depends on culture, society, or individual perspective.
- Moral beliefs vary across time and place.
- There are no absolute moral truths that apply to all people in all contexts.

Cultural Relativism

Cultural relativism defines what is “moral” as what is socially approved by the majority within a particular culture.
According to this view:

- An action is considered ethical if it is accepted or approved by the society in which it occurs.
- The same action may be considered immoral in another culture that disapproves of it.
- There is no universal moral standard that applies to all cultures.

In other words, morality is determined by cultural norms and social consensus rather than by objective or universal principles.

Ethical Criticisms of Cultural Relativism

- It equates morality with social approval, meaning that whatever the majority accepts becomes “right,” regardless of justice or fairness.
- It weakens independent moral reasoning, since individuals are expected to follow cultural norms rather than critically evaluate them.
- It creates internal inconsistency, particularly when it promotes tolerance while also claiming that no culture can be judged as better or worse than another.
- It struggles to address situations where individuals belong to multiple social groups with conflicting moral expectations.
- It makes moral reform difficult to defend, because those who challenge unjust traditions would automatically be considered immoral within their own culture.

The Cultural Differences Argument

Premise 1: Different cultures have different moral codes.
Conclusion: Therefore, there is no objective moral truth. Right and wrong are merely matters of opinion, varying from culture to culture.

Is This Argument Correct?

Just because cultures disagree about morality does not automatically mean that there is no objective moral truth.
For example:
In the past, societies disagreed about whether the Earth was flat or round.
The disagreement did not mean there was no correct answer.
Similarly:
Cultural disagreement about morality does not prove that morality is purely subjective.